

HEADHUNTER

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IN SHORT: You used to be a hacker for the USMC, but you've had some health issues.

THE WORST THING THAT EVER HAPPENED

TO YOU: You were MOS o651 in the Marine Corps, a cyber network operator. In a general sense, as a marine, you were expected to be ready for a gunfight. But specifically, your job was to keep computers running, even on the battlefield. So you weren't *scheduled* to get in the real shit, but... well, things get hectic quick.

You were in trying to re-establish comms and analysis for a unit when they got overrun, and you tooled up to shoot back. You saw a guy in black. He was running across the area of operations, dark cloth swirling like a bat's wing. Bullets were pinging everywhere. Stuff was blowing up... your stuff, their stuff, civilians running around. Everything was nuts. You pulled the trigger because, in a general sense, as a marine, you're a trigger-puller.

When things seemed to be getting calmer, you broke cover to reconnect with the guys whose computers you'd come to fix, and you saw the dude in black. He was an old guy. He didn't have any gun. He wasn't even wearing black; his robe was dark blue. You'd hit him in the back. He must have been running away but once you tagged him, he dropped and dragged. You could see it. The smear of blood where he pulled himself by his arms. It looked like an exclamation point, with his body at the end as the dot at the bottom. You'd shot him, and he dragged himself ten feet in what must have been terrible pain, and then he died. Shit.

You were processing that when something behind you went up and then it was your turn. *You* caught metal in your back. *You* dropped. But for you there was a corpsman, and painkillers, and an evac chopper, and surgeons in Germany.

Physical therapy was a real bitch, and you've locked horns with the VA more times than you can count, but you can walk now. Sometimes not for very far, but that's what the chair's for. The other day you walked a whole mile. You had to sit in your car for twenty minutes before you could make it back into your house, but it was a whole mile.



WHERE YOU ARE NOW: As far away from the fucking military as you can get. You have skills—when you were laid up in the hospital, facedown and healing from spinal surgeries, you kept up to date on your software certificates. There's only so much streaming TV you can take. You're kind of a bitter criminal loner, to be honest. You've stolen some stuff with Jesse and Doctor A. They're weirdos, but all right. They're an OK crew. And every day your legs get stronger.

YOUR INTRODUCTION TO THE OCCULT:

This Mexican lady, Jesse called her a “yerbero”? She fixed your pill addiction. (Yes, you wound up with a painkiller addiction. The leg and spine operations gave you a *lot of pain*, all right?) You knew you were going off the rails, you'd alienated your family (mostly by stealing from them, also with some yelling and threats), you *knew* you weren't who you were supposed to be, and then Jesse introduced you to Guadalupe, who put you through this ritual where you had to hold a live scorpion in your mouth and have it sting your tongue, and you blacked out and had some weird, *weird* visions but... you recovered from that, got rehydrated, and you don't want the pills any more. You can't actually *imagine* wanting the pills; it has become a very strange, broad blank spot in your mind. Guadalupe knew her shit. It's not anything that'll shut up Neil DeGrasse Tyson, but you know it was magick.

WHY ARE YOU WILLING TO DRIVE TO CANADA AND ROB A MUSEUM?:

Doctor A says it's necessary. There's this big stone head there, like two feet tall, and according to Doctor A, when it was taken out of its mound in Ohio and put on display, back in like 2003, that was when everything really started going wrong. The world's sick and only going to get worse until that head's back where it belongs.

Doctor A has been known to get a little obsessive, but as soon as you saw the picture of the head, you were all in. You've seen it before. When you were in scorpion-tongue dream state, you SAW THAT HEAD and it said it would help you kick your addiction in the ass but that then, one day you'd owe it. At the time, you wrote it off as peyote and dehydration, but you'd never seen it before the vision and you really don't want to renege on something that got you off the oxy.

A COUPLE OTHER THINGS YOU SHOULD

KNOW: The year is 2017 and you don't speak French.

THE REST OF THE CREW

- **Dr. Angel Culbard:** Your stable rock, balancing good sense with a desire to protect humankind from the weird, the bad, and the ugly. Maybe a little off-balanced away from the good sense side.
- **Karen Conti:** She's impressive! Doctor A knows about some weird stuff, and Jess can maybe influence stuff weirdly, but Karen is weird stuff. You're... not exactly sure what her limits are. Except that she hates to drive the car.
- **Jesse Viscarrat:** He's the one you like best, honestly. You have the most in common in terms of age, interest, and willingness to break laws sooner rather than later. Like the doc, Jesse's balancing getting by with saving the world, but leans way more towards the self-interest side, unlike the doctor.
- **Clossoné Farr:** Karen's daughter. You guess Leo Farr was the dad? She's OK—friendly, a bright kid, but you're a little hesitant to get her in all this crime stuff. On one hand, she's the same age you were when you went off to join a shooting war. On the other hand, look how *that* played out.

YOUR JUNK

- A remote server stored in Jesse's cousin's basement.
- Four desktop computers of varying degrees of power
- Three laptop computers, ranging from OK to quite good
- Two tablet computers—one each Mac & PC
- AR-10 14" tactical rifle chambered for .308
- Glock G17 pistol with both 17- and 33-round magazines
- 7" Ka-Bar utility knife
- .38 Special revolver with five shots. Your granddad's old gun. You had a speed loader for it once, but you can't find it now.
- Medline Lightweight wheelchair
- Drive-brand bariatric steel forearm crutches
- 2014 Ford E-Series windowless cargo van
- Just a shit-ton of radio and communications gear
- Android “official” phone
- Five burner phones

